

OH.4 Where to File Directory

Ohio publishes the answer to "does anybody permit my parcel?" — here is how to get it for your own address, and the offices that exist either way.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Ohio writes one residential code for the whole state and applies it to your house by its own terms — and then, in that same code, excuses you from submitting plans, obtaining approvals, requesting inspections and getting a certificate of occupancy if no certified residential building department has jurisdiction over your parcel. What never depends on that is the code standard itself, the sewage treatment system permit, the private water system permit, and the contract and lien rules. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it. Every web address here returned a live page in September 2026. Offices move; the lookup tool in the next section outlives any printed list.

OHIO PUBLISHES THE ANSWER — AND IT IS A MAP

This is the single most useful thing in the Ohio kit. The Board of Building Standards maintains an **address-searchable lookup** that tells you which jurisdiction, if any, has residential code-enforcement authority over a specific parcel — and it reports residential and commercial certification **separately**, which is exactly the distinction that decides whether your house needs a permit.

The Board of Building Standards' own description of the tool

"The information provided by this application is based on the records of the Board of Building Standards to help an owner identify the entity or entities that have **commercial or residential code enforcement authority based on address**. The owner is responsible for confirming with the listed jurisdiction or entity of its authority."

How to run it. Go to **com.ohio.gov** and search for the Board of Building Standards, then follow *Building Departments to Building Department Look Up*. Enter the parcel address. Read four things off the result and write all four on the directory page at the end of this document.

Four things to read off your result

	Field	What it tells you
1	Residential certified — yes or no	This is the question. If every entity returned for your address says <i>No</i> , there is no residential building permit for your house, and no state office can issue you one

Four things to read off your result

	Field	What it tells you
2	Which entity holds it	You may get a municipal record and a county record for the same address. The municipality's own department governs inside its corporation limits; the county's covers unincorporated territory and municipalities without their own
3	Commercial certified — separately	Frequently Yes where residential is No. A commercial-only department cannot permit or inspect your house, however large it is. Do not read a staffed building department as an answer to the residential question
4	The plumbing entity	The dataset names it in its own field, and it is very often the county health district rather than the building department — which is what § 3781.03(C) predicts. Check it separately or you will miss a required inspection

*The lookup is a live map application, so it needs a browser rather than a printout — which is precisely why it is worth more than any list we could print. It is maintained by the office that issues the certifications, so it updates when a jurisdiction's status changes. **Re-run it before any later phase of your build:** a municipality or a county can apply for residential certification at any time, and the answer you got at foundation is not guaranteed at framing.*

WHAT THAT DATA SHOWS ABOUT OHIO AS A WHOLE

We downloaded the Board's own dataset in September 2026 and counted it. The picture explains why Ohio owner-builders get such wildly different answers from each other.

Residential and commercial certification, from the Board's own dataset (September 2026)

Layer	Residential certified	Commercial certified	What it means
Counties	36 of 88	64 of 88	Fewer than half of Ohio's counties hold county-wide residential certification — but nearly three quarters hold commercial
Cities and villages	475 of 921	656 of 921	Municipal residential certification is close to a coin flip. Being inside a city or village settles nothing by itself
Townships	almost none	almost none	Ten residential-certified township records in the entire dataset. A township zoning inspector is not a building inspector, and the two offices answer different questions

Look at the gap between those two columns. Sixty-four counties took commercial certification; thirty-six took residential. That is not an accident of staffing — it is the statute showing up in behavior. Under § 3791.04(A)(1)(a), if no local department is certified for *nonresidential* work, plans go to the state Superintendent of Industrial Compliance. Under (b), if none is certified for *residential* work, **nothing goes anywhere**. Ohio built a backstop for warehouses and not for houses, and counties responded exactly as you would expect.

The 23 counties with no residential certification anywhere in them

Fifty-two counties hold no *county-wide* residential certification — but in twenty-nine of those, a city or village inside the county runs its own certified department. **In the twenty-three below, no county, no municipality and no township holds residential certification at all.** These are the places where, as things stood in September 2026, there was genuinely no residential building permit to be had anywhere within the county line.

Adams, Auglaize, Belmont, Coshocton, Guernsey, Hardin, Harrison, Holmes, Lawrence, Marion, Mercer, Monroe, Morgan, Morrow, Noble, Perry, Putnam, Seneca, Tuscarawas, Van Wert, Vinton, Williams and Wyandot.

The other twenty-nine are patchwork counties — the county is not certified but part of it is covered municipally: Allen, Ashland, Athens, Carroll, Columbiana, Crawford, Cuyahoga, Defiance, Erie, Fairfield, Fulton, Gallia, Hancock, Henry, Highland, Hocking, Huron, Jackson, Jefferson, Knox, Lorain, Meigs, Muskingum, Paulding, Pike, Ross, Sandusky, Scioto and Washington. **Cuyahoga is the extreme case:** the county holds no residential certification while most of the cities inside it do. In a patchwork county the answer changes at the city line, which is exactly why you check the address rather than the county.

And twenty-nine counties are certified for commercial work but not residential — Allen, Ashland, Auglaize, Belmont, Coshocton, Crawford, Fairfield, Fulton, Gallia, Guernsey, Hancock, Henry, Holmes, Huron, Lawrence, Meigs, Mercer, Monroe, Morgan, Muskingum, Noble, Perry, Pike, Ross, Sandusky, Seneca, Tuscarawas, Washington and Wyandot. They have a staffed building department with an office and a counter, and **it cannot issue a permit for your house.** Do not read the existence of a department as an answer to the residential question.

*The thirty-six counties with county-wide residential certification are Ashtabula, Brown, Butler, Champaign, Clark, Clermont, Clinton, Darke, Delaware, Fayette, Franklin, Geauga, Greene, Hamilton, Lake, Licking, Logan, Lucas, Madison, Mahoning, Medina, Miami, Montgomery, Ottawa, Pickaway, Portage, Preble, Richland, Shelby, Stark, Summit, Trumbull, Union, Warren, Wayne and Wood. All of these figures were computed from the Board of Building Standards' own published dataset on 2 September 2026 and checked twice. Shared arrangements are visible in it: Darke, Miami and Shelby counties list one combined residential department, and Akron shares an address with Summit County. **Status changes** — a legislative body can apply for certification at any time. Treat every list on this page as a dated snapshot and run the lookup for your own parcel.*

WHICH LAYER DOES WHAT

Ohio land is either inside a municipal corporation — a city or a village — or it is unincorporated, in which case it sits in a township. Every parcel is also in exactly one of eighty-eight counties. The layers do not overlap the way people assume, and the office that stops your build is often not the one you were expecting.

Seven approvals, six different offices

What you need	Who has it
Building permit and inspections	A municipal, county or (very rarely) township building department — only if certified for residential buildings at that address
Zoning certificate	A different office almost always. Municipalities zone under their own ordinances; townships under R.C. Chapter 519 and counties under Chapter 303, both only in unincorporated territory . A parcel is under county or township zoning, not both — and some unincorporated Ohio has neither
Sewage system and private water	The local board of health, always, statewide, whether or not any building department exists. This is the most reliable sentence in the whole kit
Plumbing	Its own statutory track: the Division of Industrial Compliance, a board of health, a certified municipal building-inspection department, or a contracting county department (§ 3781.03(C)). Check the lookup's plumbing field
Driveway or culvert	Whoever owns the road. State route: the Department of Transportation district. County road: the county engineer — "The owners of land shall construct and keep in repair all approaches or driveways from the public roads, under the direction of the county engineer " (§ 5543.16). Township road: the trustees, who "shall have control of the township roads" (§ 5571.02)
Building sewer / sanitary tap	The city engineer's department, the board of health, or the sewer purveyor — whichever supervises the system your lateral joins
Floodplain development permit	The local floodplain administrator. The Department of Natural Resources coordinates Ohio's role in the national program but does not issue your permit

Two Ohio-specific confusions worth heading off

1. A township zoning inspector is not a building inspector. They read the township zoning resolution, not the Residential Code of Ohio. They decide *where* on the lot and *whether* the use is allowed; a building department decides *how* it is built. In much of unincorporated Ohio the zoning inspector exists and the building department does not — so you can need a zoning certificate and no building permit on the same parcel. A township may also adopt a property-maintenance code under § 505.73, but that section reaches "the repair and continued maintenance of structures" and must govern "subject matter not addressed by the state residential building code" — **it is not a new-construction permit power.**

2. Villages and cities sit differently for health. Under § 3709.01, "**Each city constitutes a city health district. The townships and villages in each county shall be combined into a general health district.**" So a village normally deals with the *county's* general health district for septic and well — while often running its own building department for everything else. That split catches people, because the building-department pattern and the health-district pattern point opposite ways for exactly the same parcel. Districts also merge, so "one per county" is wrong.

THE SEQUENCE WHEN NO BUILDING DEPARTMENT IS CERTIFIED

"No building permit" is not "no paperwork." The real risk is doing these in the wrong order, because two of them constrain where the house can physically sit.

The rural sequence

	Step	Which office, and why the order
1	Confirm nobody has jurisdiction	The Board of Building Standards lookup, then the municipality and the township directly. Get it in writing and date it
2	Zoning	Township or county. Ask about setbacks, minimum lot size and accessory structures before you site anything
3	Survey and mark the lot lines	Every setback you are about to work to — septic, well, zoning — is measured from a boundary. Do this before the soil evaluation, not after
4	Soil evaluation and sewage permit	Board of health. Constrains the house position , and needs a replacement area as well as the system itself. The longest pole on a rural build
5	Private water system permit	Board of health, before drilling. Sited against the septic system, so plan the two together
6	Floodplain determination	Local floodplain administrator. You may need a document certifying you are <i>outside</i> the hazard area
7	Driveway or access permit	Decided by which road you touch — state, county or township
8	Address assignment	Usually the county's 911 or addressing office. Utilities and often the health district need it
9	Electric service	Your utility or co-op — in practice the only outside look at your wiring where no electrical permit exists. Ask early what they require
10	Utility locate	Ohio 811, free, before any excavation
11	Stormwater	Only at one acre of disturbance — or less, if your lot is part of a larger common plan of development

STATE-LEVEL ADDRESSES

All verified to resolve in September 2026. We print no phone numbers anywhere in this kit — they go stale faster than anything else on a printed page, and every office below can be reached from its own site.

What you actually need, and where it lives

To do this	Go here
Find out who permits your parcel	com.ohio.gov — Board of Building Standards, then <i>Building Departments</i> → <i>Building Department Look Up</i>
The lookup map itself	maps.ohio.gov — the Board's building department application
Read the building code free	codes.ohio.gov — Ohio Administrative Code, chapter 4101:8
Read the statutes	codes.ohio.gov — Ohio Revised Code, chapters 3781 and 3791
Verify a trade contractor's state license	elicense.ohio.gov — remember this is the commercial license; it is not required for work on a house
Find your local health district	odh.ohio.gov — <i>Find Local Health Departments</i> . The most important address in this kit on a rural build
Sewage treatment system rules and program	odh.ohio.gov — Sewage Treatment Systems; rules at codes.ohio.gov under OAC 3701-29
Private water system rules	codes.ohio.gov — OAC 3701-28
Construction stormwater permit	epa.ohio.gov — Division of Surface Water, stormwater program
Water well logs and drilling records	waterwells.ohiodnr.gov — useful for predicting depth and yield from neighboring wells before you drill
Floodplain management	ohiodnr.gov — Division of Water Resources, Floodplains
Check your flood zone	msc.fema.gov
Driveway onto a state route	transportation.ohio.gov/about/districts — find your district, then Right-of-Way & Utility Permits
Appeal a building department decision	bbalookup.com.ohio.gov — Board of Building Appeals case database
Utility locate before digging	oups.org — Ohio 811
Parcel data, and the homestead credit afterwards	Your county auditor's Real Estate or Property Search. Ohio has no statewide parcel portal — each of the 88 auditors runs their own

One warning about Ohio's state websites. The Commerce, Health, EPA and Natural Resources sites all run on the same portal, and short marketing-style addresses on them frequently return a page that loads normally and says "No content found" — a soft failure that looks like a working link. If a page looks empty, do not conclude the program was discontinued; search the agency's site for the program name instead. Every address above was checked as a live page, not merely as a link.

YOUR DIRECTORY — FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Every office that touches this build, and what it told you

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Board of Building Standards lookup — residential certified for my address? Yes / No Entity _____ Answer _____ Date _____		
☐	Which entity, and is it municipal or county? Entity _____ Layer _____		
☐	Commercial certified for the same address? (Not the same question.) Answer _____		
☐	Plumbing entity named by the lookup, and whether a plumbing permit is required Office _____ Answer _____		
☐	Municipality or village — confirmed directly Office _____ Answer _____ Date _____		
☐	Township — zoning, and whether it has any building authority Office _____ Answer _____ Date _____		
☐	County — building department and zoning Office _____ Answer _____ Date _____		
☐	Local health district — the sanitarian handling my parcel District _____ Name _____		
☐	Soil evaluator engaged Name _____ Credential _____		
☐	Septic system designer Name _____ Date _____		
☐	Septic installer, and their registration Name _____ Registration _____		
☐	Private water systems contractor, and their registration Name _____ Registration _____		

Every office that touches this build, and what it told you

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Surveyor for the lot line markers Name _____		
☐	Road authority for my driveway — state, county or township Office _____		
☐	County floodplain administrator Office _____		
☐	911 addressing office Office _____		
☐	Electric utility or co-op, and its service requirements Name _____		
☐	County auditor — for the homestead credit afterwards Office _____		

Ohio is one of the few states where the answer to "does anybody permit my parcel?" is published, authoritative and free — so there is no excuse for guessing, and no reason to accept a neighbor's answer about a different address. Run the lookup, get the confirmation in writing, date it, and keep the email behind this sheet. Re-check before any later phase: a jurisdiction can apply for residential certification at any time, and the answer that was true at your foundation is not guaranteed at your framing.